A/PROF CHAMARA BASNAYAKE
MBBS, PhD, FRACP
Gastroenterologist & Endoscopist
PN 421926PK

FOCUS GASTROENTEROLOGY

15 April 2026

Dr Jodie Gostin
Airlie Women's Clinic & Family Medical Centre

Dear Dr Gostin,

Re: Mrs Maria Bernardo
DOB: 1977-04-06
Address: 39 Elizabeth Street, BENTLEIGH EAST VIC 3165

Summary

- **Maintenance of oesophageal symptom control on reduced doses of fluoxetine and amitriptyline.**
- **Discussion regarding vocal cord dysfunction (VCD) and its shared neuro-sensitivity pathways with gastrointestinal symptoms.**
- **Plan to gradually wean bowel medication over the coming months.**
- **Recommendation to defer further fluoxetine weaning for 6 to 12 months to ensure clinical stability.**
- **No action required by you.**

I had the pleasure of conducting a review with Marie. We discussed her current progress, particularly regarding the management of her oesophageal symptoms and her concurrent vocal cord dysfunction (VCD). It is encouraging to note that she remains clinically stable and is managing her symptoms well despite being on lower doses of her neuromodulators than previously. Specifically, she has reduced her fluoxetine from a peak of 80 mg down to her current dose of 60 mg.

We explored the relationship between her gastrointestinal sensitivity and her VCD. While neuromodulators such as fluoxetine and amitriptyline are highly effective in modulating the nerve pathways associated with visceral hypersensitivity in the gut, they appear to have a more limited impact on the pathways governing the vocal cords and breathing. This likely explains why her respiratory symptoms persist despite the relative success of her treatment from a

All appointments and enquires
Suite 201, 100 Victoria Parade
East Melbourne VIC 3002
Ph: 03 9650 7917
Fax: 03 9650 7910
Pager: 03 9387 1000
Email: office@focusgastro.com.au

Endoscopy locations
Epworth Freemasons Day Proc. Centre
320 Victoria Pde, East Melbourne, 3002
Hobson Healthcare Sydenham
566 Melton Hwy, Sydenham, 3037
St Vincent's Private Hospital
59 Victoria Pde, Fitzroy, 3065

gastroenterological perspective. Marie has not seen her specialist at the Alfred Clinic for over a year, and we discussed the possibility of re-engaging with that service if her VCD becomes more prominent.

Regarding her bowel function, Marie reports that her symptoms are currently well-managed. We discussed a strategy to wean the medication she currently uses for bowel frequency. I have advised her to halve the dose for one month, and if her bowel movements remain stable, she may reduce this to a quarter dose for a further month before ceasing the medication entirely.

Impression and Plan Marie is keen to further reduce her medications, particularly the fluoxetine. However, given that previous attempts to lower the dose led to a recurrence of symptoms, I have advised caution. While I am supportive of her long-term goal to cease these medications, I believe it would be most prudent to wait a further 6 to 12 months before attempting another fluoxetine reduction. If she does choose to proceed earlier, the wean must be extremely gradual, reducing by only one tablet every two months with close monitoring.

For now, she will continue with Pariet 20 mg daily, as I suspect cessation of this would lead to a prompt return of symptoms. I have provided her with the necessary prescriptions and will review her progress in six months' time.

Kind regards

Yours sincerely,

A/Prof Chamara Basnayake
Gastroenterologist

CC: Dr Amanda Richards